

NOSE JOB Healthcare workers take nasal samples from passengers arriving from other states at the Mumbai airport

> "EVEN IF OMICRON IS SHOWING MILDER SYMPTOMS, **IT DOES NOT MEAN COVID IS OVER.** WE WILL SEE MORE WAVES, AND IN UNVACCINATED POPULATIONS, THE RISE OF NEW VARIANTS"
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> **DR GAGANDEEP KANG**
> *Virologist*

two days of intensely high fever and constant coughing. I had such severe body pain that I could not get out of the bed for the entire week. I have no other illnesses, although I am overweight. You hear that Covid is mild and just a fever, but the fever itself is exhausting and leaves you unable to function properly. There was also a lot of psychological trauma and stress that I might have infected others in my family."

IS THE HOSPITALISATION RISK LESS IN OMICRON?

From the cases in India analysed so far, Omicron has an asymptomatic rate of 75-80 per cent, which is similar to Delta, but when it comes to serious attacks and hospitalisation, the rate is reassuringly lower. The Delta wave saw 20-25 per cent patients being admitted in hospitals, whereas only 5-10 per cent of Omicron patients have to be hospitalised, according to the Union ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW) data. But that doesn't mean the country should lower its guard. "With two fairly lethal waves behind us, there is some pandemic fatigue. Omicron has also brought to light new data and new misconceptions. A big part of the fight against the pandemic is information management. Less hospitalisation does not mean you take Omicron lightly," says Dr Anupam Sibal, medical director of the Apollo Group of Hospitals.

The real risk is far higher for those with comorbid ailments such as asthma, hypertension, heart disease and cancer. Reports from Delhi's largest Covid facility, the LNJP Hospital, reveal that most patients getting admitted have comorbidities. "It can be lethal for patients who have weak immune systems or problems in any of their organs or are recovering from surgery," says Mumbai-based nephrologist Dr Atul Ingale. "Age, too, makes a patient more vulnerable to severe disease. All respiratory diseases, not just Covid, can cause problems in those with comorbid conditions but Covid, due to how fast it spreads, is the most concerning and the reason why we shouldn't take it lightly." This is why MoHFW has announced that those above 60 years and with comorbidities are eligible for a third dose of the vaccine (see accompanying report, *Confidence Booster*).

Also, while the percentage of those being hospitalised may be lower, the sheer number of people getting infected and who need treatment, warn experts, may test the country's health infrastructure. "You don't want a tsunami of hospitalisations," says Dr Mishra. "The chain of transmission has to be broken to keep those at high risk safe and to prevent further opportunities for the virus to mutate." Adds Dr Paul: "The need for hospital care may increase suddenly. It is too soon to be certain about the rate of hospitalisations." Going by the current 5-10 per cent rate of hospitalisation and an expected peak of 1 million cases a day, India would require 50,000-100,000 beds a day. and 350,000-700,000 beds at the peak, assuming that an average patient will require seven days of hospitalisation. India currently has 1.8 million isolation beds, 500,000 oxygen supported beds and 140,000 ICU beds, leaving it in a better state of preparedness than during the Delta wave. However, should infection be concentrated